

THE WRONG WIDOW

A printable historical family mystery

Player frame: 1890–1892

Adjudicate competing Civil War widow's pension claims from supplied county and military paper

Two women claim the same soldier's widow's pension. Decide which claim the records can carry — and reconstruct what happened without treating any one document as gospel.

This is the player case. Keep hints.pdf and sealed-solution.pdf closed until you need them.

Solo or small group · One evening · US Letter

How to investigate

Work in short loops: **observe** what a document asserts → form a **hypothesis** → **pull** the next record from the research catalog → **compare** witnesses → **revise**. Records disagree the way witnesses disagree. No single page is gospel.

Use the worksheets. Cite exhibit codes (D001, D002, ...) when you answer. When you are ready, answer the final adjudication questions — then open the sealed solution only after you commit.

Spoiler warning: Do not open sealed-solution.pdf until you have submitted (or firmly written) your answers. hints.pdf is progressive; open one rung at a time if stuck.

Cold open — the dispute

Two women have filed Civil War widow's pension claims for the same enlisted man. The bureau papers are already in conflict. You are walking into an open dispute.

Read exhibits **D001** → **D002** → **D003** → **D004** in that order. Then verify both marriages.

D001

Pension conflict cover / bureau note — dual widow claims

Date: 1890-01-15 **Place:** U.S. Pension Bureau

UNITED STATES PENSION BUREAU

Internal Routing Note — Contested Widow Claims

Soldier: Elias M. Corbett, Pvt, Co. C, 36th Indiana Infantry

Claimant A: Martha Jane Corbett (widow claim)

Claimant B: Lydia Ann Corbett (widow claim)

Status: both pending / contested

Both files are pending. No adjudication entered. Forward county and military paper as assembled.

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D002

Martha Jane Corbett — widow's pension claim excerpt

Date: 1888-03-20 **Place:** Ripley County, Indiana

WIDOW'S PENSION CLAIM — EXCERPT

Claimant: **Martha Jane Corbett**

Maiden name: Ashby

Marriage claimed: **1858-03-12**, Ripley County, Indiana

Asserted soldier death: wartime death of disease (hospital word)

Children named: Sarah Elizabeth Corbett, James William Corbett

Claimant states she married the soldier before his enlistment and received word that he died of disease in hospital during the war. She asks for widow's pension on that marriage and that death.

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D003

Lydia Ann Corbett — widow's pension claim excerpt

Date: 1888-05-12 **Place:** Jefferson County, Indiana

WIDOW'S PENSION CLAIM — EXCERPT

Claimant: Lydia Ann Corbett

Maiden name: Briggs

Marriage claimed: **1866-06-04**, Jefferson County, Indiana

Asserted soldier death: 1887-02-14 pneumonia

Children named: Mary Ellen Corbett, John Henry Corbett, Anna Belle Corbett

Claimant's stated belief: first wife died of fever before they met (as told by Elias)

Claimant asks for widow's pension on the 1866 marriage and the 1887 death, naming herself as his widow.

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D004

1887 Jefferson County death register — Elias Corbett

Date: 1887-02-14 **Place:** Jefferson County, Indiana

JEFFERSON COUNTY — DEATH REGISTER

Decedent: Elias Corbett

Date of death: 1887-02-14

Cause: pneumonia

Place: Madison area, Jefferson County

Physician: Dr. Horace Mead

Widow / informant wife:

Lydia Corbett

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

First research ask

What does each woman assert, and can both marriages be verified as recorded events?

Use the research catalog below. Each cue unlocks from dates, places, and names already on D001–D004 (and from records you unlock next). You do not need hidden knowledge to find the next pull.

Research catalog

Index of research exhibits D005–D017. Unlock cues are written from opening paper — not from author-only knowledge.

Code	Record	How you find it (cue from paper you already have)
D005	1858 Ripley County marriage register	From D002: marriage date 1858-03-12 + Ripley County → pull Corbett/Ashby register for that date/county.
D006	1866 Jefferson County marriage register	From D003: marriage date 1866-06-04 + Jefferson County → pull Corbett/Briggs register (groom status as recorded).
D007	Hospital register line — Nashville	From D001: soldier Co. C, 36th Indiana Infantry → pull hospital/convalescent lines for that unit.
D008	Company muster / descriptive roll	From D001: same unit Co. C, 36th Indiana → pull company muster fate line for the named soldier.
D009	1860 Federal Census — Ripley household	From D002: Ripley + Elias/Martha + child Sarah → pre-war household schedule.
D010	1870 Federal Census — Jefferson household	From D003/D004: Jefferson County + Lydia household after the 1866 marriage date.
D011	1880 Federal Census — Jefferson household	From D003: Jefferson + Lydia + children named on her claim → later schedule.
D012	1870/1880 Census — Martha household, Ripley	From D002: Ripley + Martha Corbett + children Sarah & James → postwar widow-head schedules.
D013	1887 burial / death certificate extract	From D004: death 1887-02-14 Jefferson → burial/death naming follow-up.
D014	Divorce-search negative — named parties	From D005 parties (Elias M. Corbett & Martha Jane Ashby) + counties already on D002/D003 (Ripley, Jefferson), years 1858–1887.
D015	Hospital register line — Nashville (additional)	From D007 hospital context: scan nearby Corbett/Corbit hospital deaths in Nashville registers; compare unit/age/residence.
D016	Divorce decree extract — Ripley County	Side result when searching divorces near D005 parties in Ripley — compare every letter of both surnames.
D017	Neighboring remarriage pension note (example)	Optional teaching file from Jefferson County widow-pension practice — labeled neighboring/example; NOT a third claimant on this soldier.

Note on D017: Neighboring/example remarriage file only — not a claimant on Elias M. Corbett's contested pension.

Research exhibits

Pull these as your investigation requires. Exhibit codes match the catalog.

D005

1858 Ripley County marriage register — Corbett / Ashby

Date: 1858-03-12 **Place:** Ripley County, Indiana

RIPLEY COUNTY MARRIAGE REGISTER

Groom: Elias M. Corbett

Bride: Martha Jane Ashby

Date: 1858-03-12

County: Ripley

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D006

1866 Jefferson County marriage — Corbett / Briggs (groom: widower)

Date: 1866-06-04 **Place:** Jefferson County, Indiana

JEFFERSON COUNTY MARRIAGE REGISTER

Groom: Elias M. Corbett

Groom status (as recorded): widower

Bride: Lydia Ann Briggs

Date: 1866-06-04

Officiant: Rev. Josiah Hale

County: Jefferson

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D007

Hospital line — Elias M. Corbett dead of disease

Date: 1863-11-12 **Place:** U.S. General Hospital No. 8 / convalescent barracks, Nashville, Tennessee

U.S. GENERAL HOSPITAL — REGISTER LINE

U.S. General Hospital No. 8 / convalescent barracks, Nashville, Tennessee

Name: Elias M. Corbett

Unit: Co. C, 36th Indiana Infantry

Admitted: 1863-10-20

Date: 1863-11-12

Status:

dead of disease

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D008

Company muster — deserted / missing supposed dead

Date: 1863-12-01 **Place:** Co. C, 36th Indiana Infantry

COMPANY MUSTER / DESCRIPTIVE ROLL

Co. C, 36th Indiana Infantry

Name: Eli Corbett

Unit: Co. C, 36th Indiana Infantry

Approx. date: 1863-12-01

Context: after leaving convalescence, Nashville

Status:

deserted / missing — supposed dead

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D009

1860 Federal Census — Elias + Martha household, Ripley Co.

Date: 1860-06-01 **Place:** Ripley County, Indiana

1860 FEDERAL CENSUS — SCHEDULE EXTRACT

Ripley County, Indiana — 1860-06-01

Name	Age	Relationship
Elias Corbett	24	Head
Martha Corbett	20	Wife
Sarah E. Corbett	1	Daughter

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D010

1870 Federal Census — Elias + Lydia household, Jefferson Co.

Date: 1870-06-01 **Place:** Jefferson County, Indiana

1870 FEDERAL CENSUS — SCHEDULE EXTRACT

Jefferson County, Indiana — 1870-06-01

Name	Age	Relationship
Elias Corbit	35	Head
Lydia Corbett	25	Wife
Mary E. Corbett	2	Daughter
John H. Corbett	3/12	Son

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D011

1880 Federal Census — Elias + Lydia household, Jefferson Co.

Date: 1880-06-01 Place: Jefferson County, Indiana

1880 FEDERAL CENSUS — SCHEDULE EXTRACT

Jefferson County, Indiana — 1880-06-01

Name	Age	Relationship
Eli Corbett	43	Head
Lydia Corbett	35	Wife
Mary Ellen Corbett	12	Daughter
John Henry Corbett	10	Son
Anna Belle Corbett	5	Daughter

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D012

1870/1880 Federal Census — Martha Corbett widow household, Ripley Co.

Date: 1870-06-01 Place: Ripley County, Indiana

FEDERAL CENSUS — MARTHA CORBETT HOUSEHOLD

Ripley County, Indiana

1870 schedule

Name	Age	Relationship
Martha Corbett	30	Head (widow)
Sarah Corbett	10	Daughter
James Corbett	8	Son

1880 schedule

Name	Age	Relationship
Martha Corbett	40	Head (widow)
James W. Corbett	18	Son
Abigail Ashby	38	Sister

Remarriage noted on these schedules: none recorded

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D013

1887 burial / death certificate naming Lydia

Date: 1887-02-16 **Place:** Jefferson County, Indiana

BURIAL / DEATH CERTIFICATE EXTRACT

Decedent: Elias M. Corbett

Burial date: 1887-02-16

Cause: pneumonia

Widow:

Lydia Corbett

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D014

Divorce-search negative — Elias M. Corbett & Martha Jane Ashby

Date: 1891-06-01 **Place:** Ripley County and Jefferson County, Indiana

COURT / COUNTY SEARCH RESULT

Divorce / Dissolution Search

Parties searched: Elias M. Corbett / Eli Corbett & Martha Jane Ashby / Martha J. Corbett

Counties: Ripley, Jefferson

Years searched: 1858–1887

RESULT:

NO divorce / dissolution located

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D015

Hospital register line — Silas M. Corbit, Co. B 83rd Indiana

Date: 1863-11-09 **Place:** Nashville, Tennessee

HOSPITAL REGISTER LINE — NASHVILLE

Name: Silas M. Corbit

Unit:

Co. B, 83rd Indiana Infantry

Residence:

Dearborn County, Indiana

Age (approx.):

23

Status: dead of disease

Date: 1863-11-09

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D016

Ripley County divorce decree — Eli Corbin & Martha Ann Ashley

Date: 1865-08-08 **Place:** Ripley County, Indiana

RIPLEY COUNTY — DIVORCE DECREE EXTRACT

Husband:

Eli Corbin

Wife:

Martha Ann Ashley

Decree date: 1865-08-08

County: Ripley

Names as recorded on the decree. Compare letter-by-letter to any other couple under study.

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

D017

Pension note — Harriet Whitcomb Keller (remarriage)

Date: 1869-02-01 **Place:** Jefferson County, Indiana

NEIGHBORING / EXAMPLE FILE — NOT A CLAIMANT ON ELIAS M. CORBETT'S PENSION

PENSION NOTE — REMARRIAGE RULE

This paper is from a neighboring Jefferson County widow's file. It is supplied only to illustrate how remarriage can affect widow-pension eligibility. It is **not** Claimant C on Elias M. Corbett's contested file.

Widow: Harriet Whitcomb

First husband: George Whitcomb (died in service 1864)

Remarriage: Amos Keller, 1868-09-22

Effect noted: widow pension eligibility affected by remarriage

Fictional facsimile for game use — not an authentic historical document.

Worksheets

Write freely. Cite exhibit codes. Do not treat these sheets as answer keys.

1. Claim comparison

What does each claimant assert? (marriage date/place, death claim, children, what would make her file look strong)

Martha Jane Corbett (from her file):

Lydia Ann Corbett (from her file):

2. War paper conflict

Hospital line vs company muster — how does each describe the soldier's fate? If they disagree, note the disagreement.

Hospital / convalescent line:

Company muster:

Conflict / working theory:

3. Household reconstruction

Sketch who lives where, and when. First household vs second household. Note remarriage (or none) as the schedules show it.

Ripley / first household:

Jefferson / second household:

Final adjudication

Answer from the open record set (D001–D017). Cite exhibits. Keep the sealed packet closed until you commit.

A. Supportable widow

Which claimant's marriage is the undissolved prior union that controls widow status? Name her and cite the paper that supports your choice.

Your answer:

Exhibit citations:

B. Claimant beliefs

What did each woman believe or assert in her file? (Sincere vs knowingly false is a separate layer — stay with what the open paper shows.)

Your answer:

Exhibit citations:

C. What happened

Reconstruct the soldier's wartime fate from the conflicting military paper and his postwar life. When did he die?

Your answer:

Exhibit citations:

D. Why both claims look real

Which documents legitimately support each file? Keep “record says X” separate from “X happened.”

Your answer:

Exhibit citations:

When finished: seal your answers, then open sealed-solution.pdf. Use hints.pdf only if stuck (one rung at a time).